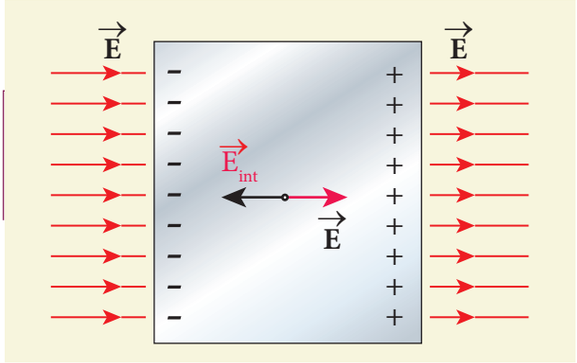


Figure 1.42 Electric field of conductors

Before applying the external electric field, the free electrons in the conductor are uniformly distributed in the conductor. When an electric field is applied, the free electrons accelerate to the left causing the left plate to be negatively charged and the right plate to be positively charged as shown in Figure 1.42.

Due to this realignment of free electrons, there will be an internal electric field created inside the conductor which increases until it nullifies the external electric field. Once the external electric field is nullified the conductor is said to be in electrostatic equilibrium. The time taken by a conductor to reach electrostatic equilibrium is in the order of 10^{-16}s, which can be taken as almost instantaneous.

(ii) There is no net charge inside the conductors. The charges must reside only on the surface of the conductors.

We can prove this property using Gauss law. Consider an arbitrarily shaped conductor as shown in Figure 1.43.

A Gaussian surface is drawn inside the conductor such that it is very close to the surface of the conductor. Since the electric field is zero everywhere inside the conductor, the net electric flux is also zero over this Gaussian surface. From Gauss's law, this implies that there is no net charge inside the conductor. Even if some charge is introduced

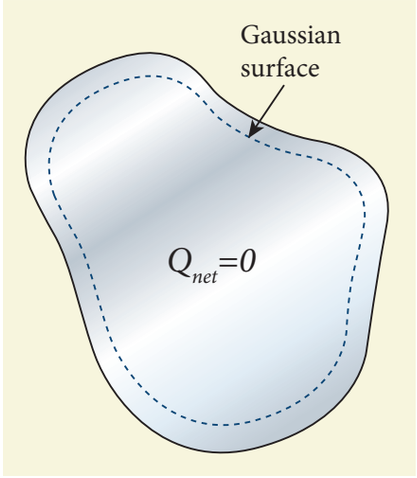


Figure 1.43 No net charge inside the conductor

inside the conductor, it immediately reaches the surface of the conductor.

(iii) The electric field outside the conductor is perpendicular to the surface of the conductor and has a magnitude of $\frac{\sigma}{\epsilon_0}$ where σ is the surface charge density at that point.

If the electric field has components parallel to the surface of the conductor, then free electrons on the surface of the conductor would experience acceleration (Figure 1.44(a)). This means that the

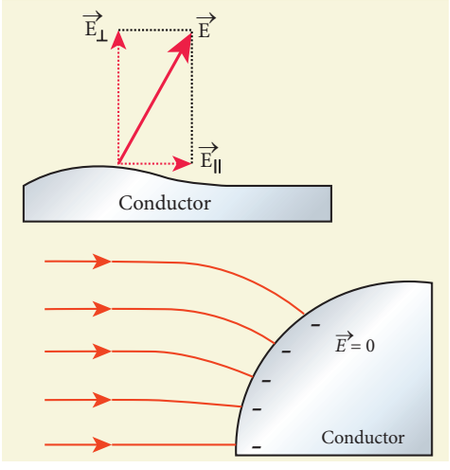


Figure 1.44 (a) Electric field is along the surface (b)Electric field is perpendicular to the surface of the conductor

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